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HOW DOES ONE DEAL WITH THAT 'one bad day'? Forget it and move on, the manual says. Rohit Sharma did exactly that. Only, it took him about 223 days to bury the ghost of the Ahmedabad 2023 one-day World Cup final. "Last night was a bad dream, right? I think the final is tomorrow" is how the skipper would later recall that fateful November night. It was no surprise then that on June 29, 2024, he lay face down on the turf of Kensington Oval in Barbados, minutes after the T20 World Cup was won—in one of the most endearing images from India's triumph—with his eyes closed, almost as if to force himself into another slumber and dream. "I started the game in 2007 winning the [T20] World Cup and to leave the game winning it, that's a tailor-made situation for me," he says. "Life has come full circle...it has been brilliant."

But before lifting its fourth World Cup trophy across both formats, Team India had been caught napping on more than one crucial occasion. None was more critical than the semi-finals of the last edition of the T20 World Cup two years ago where they lay exposed before a rampaging England, the eventual champions. Losing by a margin of 10 wickets on a good batting track in Adelaide, it was evident that the Men in Blue were well behind the curve in T20 cricket. Something had to change.

Post the 2022 T20 World Cup exit, the holy trinity of Indian cricket—Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli and Rahul Dravid—found themselves in the firing line. Whilst no one, including them, spelt out Ro-Ko's (Rohit-Kohli) imminent retirement from T20Is, it was understood that the 2024 edition was going to be their last bow. Dravid, on the other hand, extended his contract by another six months after the 50-over World Cup. Clearly, there was unfinished business to attend to. He would later explain, speaking right after the 2024 final, "This isn't the journey of one month of the World Cup, this is a journey of two years. The construction of this team, the skills and players we wanted, the balance, all those efforts just culminated and came together on this beautiful afternoon in Barbados."

It wasn't the easiest of build-ups to this tournament for Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli either. A high-flying Hardik Pandya had been